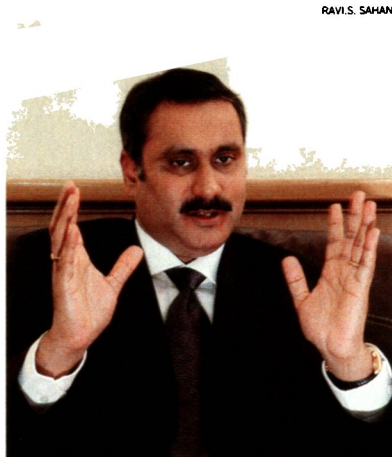


with the way MCI is functioning now.”

The trouble began when an MCI team inspected the university's facilities in August last year and recommended withdrawal of recognition to the Union Health Ministry. The Centre then referred the case to the state Government, which in its January 2008 report said that eight of 11 issues raised by the MCI had been verified and were addressed by the institution. A central inspection team then visited the medical colleges in May. With its results pending for over a month at the ministry, KMC completed the admission



The Health Ministry served the notice on reducing intake of students to Manipal University on September 29, a day before students could withdraw.



process as per the normal course. A gazette notification issued by the Health Ministry after a week of admissions, said: “MBBS of Manipal University shall be a recognised qualification when granted in or before 2008.”

Manipal Group Chairman Ramdas Pai says clarification was sent on the observations of the inspection team and it was only when Ramadoss refused to meet, did they seek the help of the Prime Minister's Office. The faculty and the students hoped for smoother sailing after the meetings between Pai and Health Secretary Naresh Dayal but were surprised by the September 23 partial modification to the notice extending grant of recognised degree to 2009. More drama followed when the Health Ministry faxed a note to both the KMCS that it had decided to recognise the MBBS degrees awarded by these two

LESSONS IN FUTILITY: Library at the Manipal medical college

colleges up to 2013. The September 29 note also said foreign students should not be allowed to share the facilities and faculty meant for Indian students. The notice read: “All deficiencies should be rectified within a year, failing which these two colleges will face derecognition of MBBS degree of students admitted after the academic year 2008, and for considering the case of restoration of seats, these two colleges will be subjected to half-yearly inspections by MCI and the government of India.”

“Compared to other schools that have MCI recognition, we have better facilities and faculty but we have been unnecessarily discriminated against,” says Pai. He adds, there should be independent regulatory bodies to verify

the medical council's inspection reports of all medical colleges in India.

The biggest shock came on September 30, the last day for students to withdraw as per a Supreme Court guideline. The ministry sent the letter late on September 29 which was seen by the university officials only the next morning. It asked them to reduce the 2008 batch seats by 50 per cent, bringing it down to 250 for both colleges. Manipal University Pro-chancellor H.S. Ballal says, according to the Supreme Court, all admissions have to be completed on or before August 31 and no admissions should be made after September 30. “When we saw the notice on September 30, it was practically impossible to reduce the intake. It would also mean loss of an academic year for the students,” he says. There will be financial losses too, as the faculty was meant for 500 students, adds Ballal. The number of foreign students is within the limit fixed by the Centre, he says, adding there is no provision in the MCI Act for half-yearly inspections of medical colleges that have existed for over 50 years.

Like Gowda's call for doing away with MCI, even the National Knowledge Commission (NKC), headed by Sam Pitroda, has made several such recommendations. One of its proposals is to set up an Independent Regulatory Authority for High Education (IRAHE) to streamline regulation of higher education in the country, which at present is marked by multiplicity of regulators, often with overlapping mandates. “This is the time for the IRAHE to come into being and take full control,” says Pai.

But right now, Ballal doesn't know where his 250 students will go. ■